

Mislabeled: A Tale of Charles Dickens
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Introduction and Literature Review

Charles Dickens was well known for his characters that often embodied a grotesque and whimsical nature. His characters were often unrealistic personifications of the societal problems that he found to be the most prominent. While some of his works could be described as dark, the characters were typically stretched just far enough from reality to retain their whimsy. The characters of *Hard Times*, however, were far less whimsical than any character that Dickens had previously created; these characters were so grotesque and dreary that for a while after publication, many critics avoided addressing the novel directly. Dickens completed *Hard Times* in 1854, and still in 1948, a critic named F R Leavis lamented that *Hard Times* was the greatest of all Dickens' novels, yet "in the books and essays on Dickens, so far as I know them, it is passed over as a very minor thing" (Leavis 364). Slowly, once it did begin to gain critical attention; critics began to question the accuracy of what Dickens believed to be strictly Utilitarian characters: Thomas Gradgrind and Josiah Bounderby.

Once the potential inaccuracy of these characters was discovered, critics separated into two groups: those that found these discrepancies to be detrimental and deemed the novel unworthy of further analysis, and those that thought it best to simply ignore the problems in the Utilitarianism and focus on Dickens' overarching argument. Those in the first category, as David Lodge assesses, claim that "Dickens had taken on subject-matter that he could not or would not treat adequately: Dickens did not understand Utilitarianism well enough to attack it effectively, and in handling the theme of industrial relations falsified his own observations" (Lodge 401).

Critics such as Bernard Shaw (357), or G K Chesterton (169) fall into the second category. They ask that the problems be overlooked because, though the novel is flawed, it is still worthy of praise. Neither of these approaches consider a third possibility: that he simply mislabeled the characters as Utilitarian while describing a different ethical system. The analysis that has thus far been overlooked, will now be addressed. Thomas Gradgrind and Josiah Bounderby cannot be said to represent Utilitarianism, but instead, they act under the moral guidelines presented in Kantian Ethics.

Utilitarianism, or Lack Thereof

To understand the claims that Utilitarianism makes about the morality of an action, we must first look to Jeremy Bentham, the man credited with the foundation of Utilitarianism:

“By the principle of utility is meant that principle which approves or disapproves of every action whatsoever, according to the tendency which it appears to have to augment or diminish the happiness of the party whose interest is in question: or, what is the same thing in other words, to promote or to oppose that happiness” (Bentham 16).

Dickens’ understanding of the concept of Utilitarianism seems to stem almost entirely from his understanding of the word ‘utility’. Bentham himself preferred the phrase ‘greatest happiness’ over ‘principle of utility’¹ because “the word utility does not so clearly point to the ideas of pleasure and pain as the words happiness and felicity do” (Bentham 15). Within Utilitarianism, the term ‘utility’ is not a term used to reduce people to a state of mere usefulness, but instead is referring to an act. Acts that bring more happiness have a high quality of utility, and acts that

¹ Bentham originally referred to his system as the ‘principle of utility’. The term Utilitarianism was coined later by his student John Stuart Mill.

bring more pain have a lower quality of utility. Such a distinction is often overlooked, and grew into a common misconception that John Stuart Mill described in his book *Utilitarianism*.

John Stuart Mill was a student of Jeremy Bentham, and as such, he was able to gain an understanding of the problems and misconceptions that people may have about Utilitarianism. He described one of the biggest misconceptions as follows:

“It is often affirmed that Utilitarianism renders men cold and unsympathizing; that it chills their moral feelings toward individuals; that it makes them regard only the dry and hard consideration of the consequences of actions, not taking into their moral estimate the qualities from which those actions emanate...there is nothing in the Utilitarianism theory inconsistent with the fact that there are other things which interest us in persons besides the rightness and wrongness of their action” (Mill 57-58).

Mill describes this as a ‘gross misconception’ because it makes the assumption that Utilitarianism requires one to reduce people to their actions. He writes that while some Utilitarians may act in this manner, it is no way a symptom of the system, but of the person in general. Utilitarianism, in actuality, begs a person to consider the happiness of the involved parties in the decisions they make, requiring them to access their emotions, and the emotions of others, when considering performing any given action.

This misconception, as described by Mill, seems to be the concept that the characters Thomas Gradgrind and Josiah Bounderby were constructed under:

“Why, Mr. Bounderby was as near being Mr. Gradgrind’s bosom friend, as a man perfectly devoid of sentiment can approach that spiritual relationship towards another man perfectly devoid of sentiment” (Dickens 15; ch. 04).

Bounderby and Gradgrind present themselves as people that do not consider happiness to be a valid determinant of any decision to be made. Gradgrind does not even allow Louisa to consider happiness when deciding whether or not to marry Bounderby. Once Gradgrind proposes that she marry Bounderby, she asks if she is expected to love Bounderby (an understandable enough request of marriage). Gradgrind, the strictly logical creature that he is, tells her that she is asking the wrong questions. She need not dwell on sentiment or emotions, but look at it in terms of fact: it is a fact that Bounderby has asked Louisa to marry him, and it is a fact that they are of the same social standing, so now all she must ask is 'will I marry him' (Dickens 77; bk. 01, ch. 15). It seems that the only thing a Utilitarian would consider, love (for love, hypothetically, should bring about happiness), is the thing that Gradgrind does not expect Louisa to consider. Even in the decisions that so greatly affect the emotions of the parties involved, Gradgrind tells his daughter that emotions were not to be considered.

Such a disregard for emotions can also be seen in the opening of the novel. When Gradgrind and Bounderby visit the school to teach the children how to properly follow the 'Gradgrind philosophy', they tell the children that they are not to have any wallpaper, or carpet, in their rooms which stray from that which can be found in reality. For example, since horses do not roam around on living room walls, and flowers cannot spring up from the floorboards, they are not to have wallpaper with horses or rugs decorated with flowers (Dickens 9; bk. 01, ch. 2). A true Utilitarian would not care about the reality of horses on walls, but would only care whether or not it would make the owner of the room happy. Utilitarianism would say that that decorating the walls with horses and floor with flowers is a good decision, so long as it brings the owner pleasure, and a bad decision only if it has the opposite effect.

In the same chapter, we can see that Gradgrind finds the circus appalling for anyone to attend, whether they enjoy it or not, however, this concept is not Utilitarian. Through the concept of Utilitarianism, we may conclude that, in general, attending the circus would be a good thing – if it brings people happiness, it should be done. Obviously, the circus does not amuse everybody: some may find it boring or ridiculous. Utilitarianism, then would say that those that do find it amusing should attend the circus (so long as it does not interfere with an activity that would result in a larger sum of happiness) and those that do not enjoy it should not attend. As can be seen in the example of the circus, Utilitarianism is not a system of universality: an act that is good, or moral, for one person to commit is not necessarily good for another to commit. Utilitarianism does not allow for any action to be consistently good or consistently bad. The closest that Utilitarianism can get to a definite is to make the claim that ‘generally, this results in more pain, so it is almost always bad’ or ‘generally, this results in more happiness, so it is almost always good’. There must be room for the reverse to be true because Utilitarianism focuses on the parties involved rather than the actions: if the involved parties would receive more pleasure than pain from an act that is generally considered bad, then in that specific instance, such an act would be good.

Dickens’ True Utilitarians

Another major component to the novel can be found in Dickens’ attempt to show the ways in which the factory laborers are merely treated as tools, or items of utility. In his presentation of this treatment, he once again does not account for the ultimate goal of Utilitarianism: the greatest happiness for the greatest amount of people. This is what the factory hands want, but it is not what Gradgrind and Bounderby desire. The factory hands, in the brief

meeting that we witness, speak and act more Utilitarian than Gradgrind and Bounderby throughout the rest of the novel. In their speech, we are able to see them express the desires of a true Utilitarian:

“I tell you that the hour is come, when we must rally round one another as One united power, and crumble into dust the oppressors that too long have battened upon the plunder of our families, upon the sweat of our brows, upon the labor of our hands, upon the strength of our sinews...” (Dickens 106; bk. 02, ch. 04)

While they do not claim to be rallying for happiness per se, they are rallying for eradication of the treatment that is preventing happiness for the majority of the Coketown citizens. These workers, in their attempt to band together and remove the source of the greatest amount of pain is a Utilitarian concept. Steve Wilkens writes that according to Utilitarianism, “if pleasure is the only thing that is intrinsically good, then pain (including physical, intellectual, spiritual, or social pain), its opposite, is the only thing that is intrinsically bad” (Wilkens 84). In the removal of the source that had, as the workers announce, “battened upon the plunder of [their] families” (Dickens 106), they have sought to remove the cause of that which was intrinsically bad in their lives.

In that same meeting, they agree that they are to shun their fellow laborer, Stephen Blackpool, who will not join their union. At first, some workers are hesitant to take such drastic actions, however, it is concluded that “private feelings must yield to the common cause” (Dickens 110; bk. 02, ch. 04). This is not to say that they are ignoring feelings altogether, but they know that there will be greater happiness if they follow through with this decision. In this brief section about the factory hands, we are able to see an example of true Utilitarianism, and

through their example, we can say without a doubt that that is not the system that Gradgrind and Bounderby are personifying.

Kantian Ethics: A New System of Morals

While Gradgrind and Bounderby may not be the strict Utilitarians that Dickens thinks they are, they cannot alternatively be said to be almost-Utilitarians that do not fully embody a particular moral philosophy at all. They are consistent in the ethical system that they follow; they do not waver in their cold calculations of morals. Obviously, in the end their system falls apart altogether, however, before they realize the flaws of their system, the teaching of the ‘Gradgrind philosophy’ is consistent. For this reason, it seems that Dickens did not simply construct a misguided version of Utilitarianism, but instead he mislabeled the characters as Utilitarian while they actually follow a different ethical system. The cold calculating personality of Gradgrind and Bounderby better aligns with the premise of Kantian Ethics created by Immanuel Kant. Kant, frustrated with the empirical basis for most other ethical systems, sought to create one that could calculate decisions based on an objective standard. “An exclusively empirical philosophy, as Kant himself argues, can have nothing to say about morality: it can only encourage us to be guided by our emotions” (Paton 7). Kant sought a system that could determine morality from a logical perspective, and not from emotions which may vary from person to person. This system, rather than asserting that the determination of the morality of an action lies in happiness, claims that morality should be based on adherence to duty. Duty being such a general term, as we can feel duty toward practically anything, must be properly defined. Kant explains that duty is to be understood this way: “duty is the necessity to act out of reverence for the law” (Kant 66). The law here is not the law of the government, but the universal law. This law is determined by

considering the ‘maxim’, or intention, of any action we may commit. For that maxim to be a law, and therefore for one to feel a moral sense of duty toward that action, we must ask if we should will everyone to adhere to this maxim universally. If a universal application would result in a paradox, or what Kant calls a ‘chimerical concept’, then such an action would be immoral.

For example, would it ever be moral to steal? To determine the morality of stealing according to Kantian Ethics, we must ask if it would be acceptable for stealing to become a universal law. We can then rationalize that if everyone were to steal, the concept of stealing itself would become an empty action. If everyone were to steal, then claiming ownership of a thing would be futile because it would necessarily get stolen by a different agent acting upon their moral duty. If no one claims ownership, then the concept of stealing would become eradicated because an object that has no owner cannot be stolen. Therefore, as soon as it were deemed moral to steal, stealing would become invalidated. Under this logic, the principle of stealing would be immoral, and it would be a person’s duty to avoid such action. In *Hard Times*, we see this very thing played out when Bounderby’s bank is robbed.

As soon as Bounderby tells James Harthouse (Bounderby’s trainee, of sorts) that the bank has been robbed, Harthouse asks how much was taken. Appalled, Bounderby informs Harthouse that “it’s not the sum; it’s the fact. It’s the fact of the Bank being robbed, that’s the important circumstance” (Dickens 138). Just as Bounderby displays here, Kantian Ethics does not work in degrees, but is black and white. The amount that is stolen does not matter; stealing is immoral regardless of the severity to which the action was executed. While discussing this same issue a short while later, Bounderby uses an explanation similar to the universal maxim to explain why the perpetrator must be punished: “fellows who go in for Banks must take the consequences. If

there were no consequences, we should all go in for Banks” (Dickens 141; bk. 02, ch. 08). His claim here is that the person who robbed the bank acted immorally and therefore must face the consequences. If there were no bad consequences – if robbing the bank, or stealing, was able to be acted upon universally with no logical detriment – then, as Bounderby says, “we should all go in for banks”.

Unlike all other ethical systems, Kantian Ethics is a non-consequential system. Non-consequentialism does not consider the results of an action in determining whether or not it is moral; the morality of an action is established before it is performed.

“An action done from duty has its moral worth, *not in the purpose* to be attained by it, but in the maxim according with which it is decided upon; it depends therefore, not on the realization of the object of the action, but solely on the *principle of volition* in accordance with which, irrespective of all objects of the faculty of desire, the action has been performed” (Kant 65).

As was previously explained, Kantian Ethics does consider the logical consequences of an action to determine the morality of that action using the universal maxim. However, once an action is deemed moral, it is one’s duty to commit that action regardless of what may result; the consequences of an action do not determine whether or not it is moral. For example, even if telling a single lie was able to save somebody’s life, it is still a person’s duty to tell the truth (for lying becomes an empty action once tested against the universal maxim). Even though the consequence of telling the truth would be a person’s death, the truth is still the moral action because the results of the action are not to be taken into account.

It is important to note that a non-consequential system does not mean that there should be no punishment, or consequences, for an action performed against the universal laws. Kantian Ethics does allow for consequences of immoral action; if a crime is committed, punishment is justifiable as punishment of immoral action does not become paradoxical when applied universally. Other systems, like Utilitarianism, rely on the consequences of an action to determine whether or not that action is moral. This is the concept which non-consequentialism refers to. In Utilitarianism, one could commit an action under the assumption that that action will bring about the most happiness. If the result is more pain than happiness, then the action is immoral despite the intent of the one who committed said action. This was problematic to Kant, so in his ethical system he sought to determine what actions are moral before any actions have actually been committed. It is only the means by which an action may be considered moral that makes a system consequential or non-consequential, not the punishment of immoral action.

We can see this same concept of non-consequentialism through the system created by Gradgrind and Bounderby. They want to be able to plug in a few equations, and calculate whether or not an action is moral, rather than wait for the results. When making a decision about the fate of one child, Sissy Jupe, Gradgrind is said to have “worked out the whole matter like a sum” (Dickens 33; bk. 01, ch. 06). In several instances, we see such non-consequentialism both in Gradgrind and Bounderby themselves, as well as those that are product of their system. The calculating nature of non-consequential ethics is even displayed in young Bitzer, the student that Gradgrind and Bounderby hold to the highest esteem: “His mind was so exactly generated that he had no affections or passions. All his proceedings were the result of the nicest and coldest calculation” (Dickens 89; bk. 02, ch. 01). Such calculations were exactly what Kant sought in his

foundation of Kantian Ethics. To Kant, determining the morality of an action was too severe to leave to potentially unpredictable emotions. If taken to the extreme, a person following Kantian Ethics would be just as cold and calculating as Gradgrind and Bounderby are said to be.

Aside from the workers in the union, Coketown as a whole is described as a product of this detrimental ‘Gradgrind philosophy’, and as such the citizens of the town also adhere to non-consequentialism, and refuse to take responsibility for the moral consequences of their actions:

“Whenever a Coketowner felt he was ill used – that is to say, whenever he was not left entirely alone, and it was proposed to hold him accountable for the consequences of any of his acts – he was sure to come out with the awful menace that he would ‘sooner pitch his property into the Atlantic’” (Dickens 86; bk. 02, ch. 01).

As we can see with the vigorous pursuit of the bank robber, this is not suggesting that the members of Coketown are all criminals that simply refuse to be arrested. Instead, they have done what they should, they were morally acting upon their duty, and whatever results from that fulfilment of duty is not, according to Kantian Ethics, their responsibility.

This appears again in Bounderby’s response to Stephen Blackpool’s inquiry about getting a divorce. Stephen asks Bounderby if there is any way that he can divorce his alcoholic and abusive wife. Bounderby, advising according to his system of non-consequentialism, tells Stephen “you didn’t take your wife for fast and for loose; but for better for worse. If she has turned out worse – why, all we have got to say is she might have turned out better” (Dickens 61; bk. 01, ch. 07). To divorce her would mean that his vows – ‘for better or for worse’ – would have been a lie which, as has been noted, would not stand against the universal maxim. Not only are

the detrimental consequences of his marriage irrelevant, but it is his duty to stay true to his word and remain married to the beast of a woman.

The morality found in the adherence to duty, like that which is presented in Kantian Ethics, as well as an application of the universal maxim can be taken to the extreme (as Dickens is known to do) and necessitate the division of fact and fancy – fact being the moral option of the two. The exaltation of fact and the degradation of fancy is a prominent theme in the book:

“Coketown, to which the Messrs. Bounderby and Gradgrind now walked, was a triumph of fact; it had no greater taint of fancy in it than Mrs. Gradgrind herself...Fact, fact, fact everywhere in the material aspects of the town; fact, fact, fact everywhere in the immaterial” (Dickens 20-21; bk. 01, ch. 05).

Since this dichotomy plays such a large role, it is imperative that the ethical system ascribed to Gradgrind and Bounderby is able to justify such a division. If we apply the universal maxim to the separation of fact and fancy, we will find fancy, or scarcity of fact, to be immoral. If we assume fact is synonymous with truth (since both truth and fact must indicate certainty) then it would be moral to adhere to the facts. Fancy, then, as it is presented as the opposite of fact in this novel, would be an immoral pursuit.

“You are to be in all things regulated and governed...by fact. We hope to have, before long, a board of fact, composed of commissioners of fact, who will force the people to be a people of fact, and of nothing but fact. You must discard the word Fancy altogether. You have nothing to do with it. You are not to have, in any object of use or ornament, what would be a contradiction in fact” (Dickens 9; bk. 01, ch. 02).

Since fancy is the opposite of fact, and fact is synonymous with truth, then any reference to fancy can be said to be the opposite of truth – i.e., a lie. As Kant argued in his introduction to the universal maxim, lying is not a moral action, for if we look at lying through the universal maxim, then lying, “as soon as it were made a universal law, would be bound to annul itself” (Kant 68).

The dichotomy between fact and fancy must be present in the system that Gradgrind and Bounderby follow, and Kantian Ethics is one of the only systems that is able to ethically declare fact to be moral, and fancy to be immoral.

Conclusion

If it is determined that Gradgrind and Bounderby follow Kantian Ethics rather than Utilitarianism, then *Hard Times* can be understood as a novel that depicts the central problems in following the ethics laid out by Immanuel Kant. When critics ignore the Utilitarianism, and consequently the ethics in *Hard Times* altogether, they are ignoring the central issue that Dickens was writing about. To ignore the ethical aspect of Dickens’ argument is to reduce it to a problem of individual personalities, disregarding the central problem that he is fighting. Dickens sought a change in a system that he found to be largely flawed, and if we take away the ethical illustration presented in the novel, we take away that which Dickens found to be the overarching problem. Bernard Shaw writes that in his previous books, the central problems are “nothing but individual delinquencies, local plague-spots, negligent authorities. In *Hard Times* you will find all this changed...Coketown is the whole place; and its rich manufacturers are proud of its dirt” (Shaw 358). Unlike his previous novels, in *Hard Times* Dickens indicates the larger problem, it is no longer a matter of cruel individuals or random acts of negligence, but is a problem with a specific system. To remove that system is to reduce *Hard Times* to the level of all his other novels:

isolating a sole trait of particular individuals that may be problematic. Once we understand that he simply mislabeled the system that his novel is about, we allow ourselves the opportunity to read *Hard Times* as a firm argument against a common ethical system. Unless it is realized that Dickens attempt to write about Utilitarianism turned into a novel about Kantian Ethics, we lose a depiction of the major flaws in Kant's ethical system from the immediate consequences to the systematic collapse that such an ethical system is bound to cause.

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